Gandhi ji's giving up his clothes during the Non-Cooperation Movement when he was in Madurai on 22 September 1921 as part of his tour of the Madras Presidency, and donning his short dhoti to identify with the poor.

And when it did become unbearably cold, in Jammu and Kashmir, he did wear a jacket, a Kashmiri phiran in Srinagar and a cap to the rally, and to play with his sister in the snow. That the Yatra reached Srinagar was in itself a miracle, given that even within the organizing team there was scepticism about being granted permission. But by then the momentum that had been built up made it difficult, if not impossible, to refuse permission, as it would mean negative publicity for the government and arouse sympathy for the yatris. In Kashmir, more than anywhere else in India, where any kind of political activity had been effectively prevented since the abolition of Article 370 and the division of the state into two and downgrading into union territories, the BJY provided the first opportunity in almost three-and-a-half years for people to come out into the streets. And this they did in such huge numbers that when the Yatra entered the Kashmir Valley, the security establishment was completely overwhelmed and the security collapsed. In Srinagar as well, lakhs showed up for the grand finale rally of the Yatra, braving the snowfall and the cold.

Another aspect of the Yatra was the energizing effect it had on activists of all hues, and not only those connected with the Congress party. One, a core of around 120 mostly young people volunteered to walk the whole length of the march with Rahul Gandhi. In this group there were many who were already active in the Congress, but there were others who were not. From all accounts, it was a transformative experience. They got a real sense of the diversity and unity of India, the humanity and generosity of the common people despite the problems they faced—of poverty, unemployment, inadequate provisions for health, education and housing. But there were also thousands of others, civil society activists, of a variety of political sympathies, for whom the Yatra provided an opportunity to break out of the despondency and hopelessness that had engulfed them due to the regressive political atmosphere, which often included facing investigations from government agencies, denial of funds, arrests and